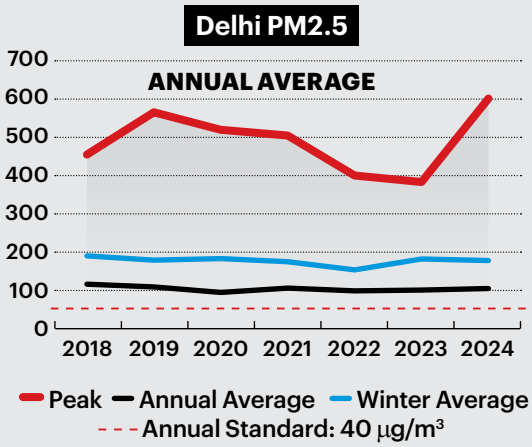
ING DELHI

THE INVISIBLE KILLER

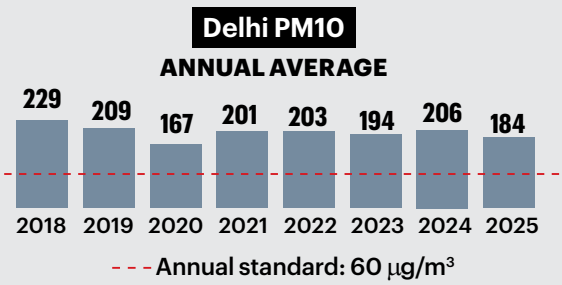
PM2.5 peaks when winter temperature inversions lock polluted air to the ground



PM2.5: *Fine particles 2.5 micrometres or smaller that can reach deep into the lungs*

AN EQUAL MENACE

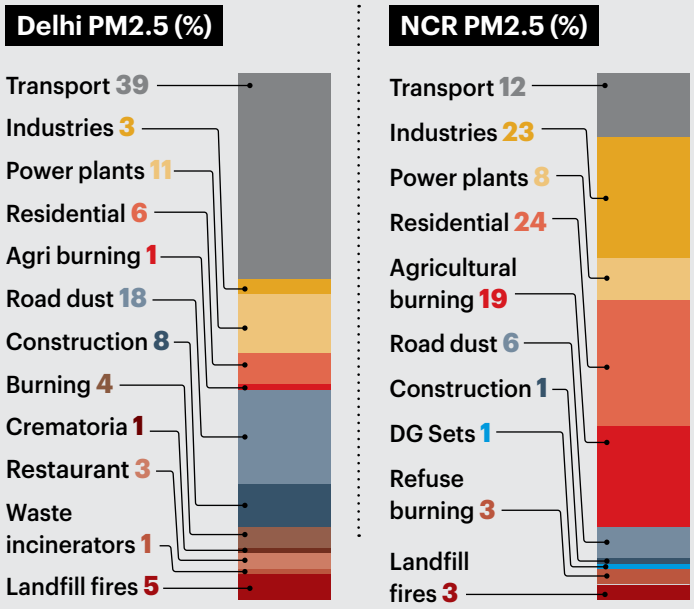
PM10 levels in the national capital can go up to 20x the WHO limit of 10 µg/m3



PM10: *Tiny air particles 10 micrometres wide or smaller, usually considered coarse pollution*

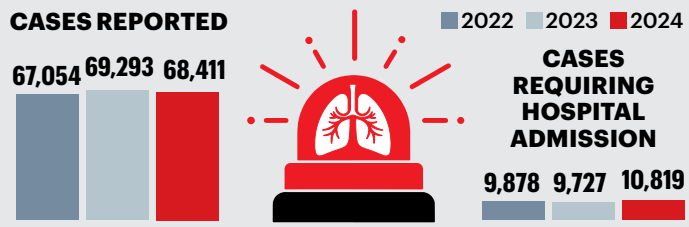
POLLUTION VILLAINS

Transport is the leading cause of high PM2.5 levels in the national capital



BREATHING TROUBLE

Hospitals are inundated with cases of acute respiratory illnesses. This is the scenario in 6* govt hospitals in Delhi in the past 3 years



*(*AIIMS, Safdarjung, Lady Hardinge, Ram Manohar Lohia, National Institute of Tuberculosis and Respiratory Diseases, Vallabhbhai Patel Chest Institute)*

Sources: TERI, CPCB, MoHFW

former deputy transport commissioner of Delhi. "Hackers sell these pen drives for as little as Rs 5,000. Not just pollution, even fitness certificates are rigged."

Delhi's biggest blind spot has been the surge in its vehicles. The capital has 15.2 million registered vehicles, nearly half the NCR's 29.7 million. And a chief reason for the surfeit of vehicles on Indian roads, including overaged ones, is the lack of reliable public transport. Delhi simply doesn't have enough buses. It needs up to 15,000, the government estimates. It currently has 2,789 electric buses—1,950 under the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) and 839 under the Delhi Integrated Multimodal Transport System (DIMTS), which runs cluster buses—but not enough EV depots, charging points or parking bays. Its 3,444 CNG buses (1,694 run by DTC, 1,750 operated under DIMTS) will be phased out by 2030, as a majority of them are over or nearing the age limit.

And while the 394-km-long Delhi Metro has been a blessing for Delhiites, it cannot be a substitute for buses; they still need feeder services. "Good feeders and increasing networks will lead to more commuters switching to the Metro," says Anuj Dayal, executive director, Delhi Metro Rail Corporation.

Experts say that Delhi needs to replace the vehicle age ban with a science-based Low Emission Zone enforced by automated cameras that fine non-compliant vehicles. This must be paired with a generous cash-for-scrap scheme and clear disincentives for keeping old, high-emission cars. For PUC centres, Delhi should adopt highway-based Remote Sensing Devices—like those in Hong Kong and China. These systems detect emissions from